

THE FIGHT AGAINST Napoleon

EUROPEAN NATIONALISM

In the aftermath of the French Revolution, Napoleon Bonaparte (national leader from 1799 and emperor from 1804) sought to conquer Europe. To this end he fought a series of wars lasting until 1815 that affected millions. Women became involved in the nationalist movements that sprang up in various European cities, and also in the colonies of the New World (see pp.154–155).

Queen's influence

Nationalism was particularly important in the German states. Prussia, the largest one, initially attempted to stay neutral under the leadership of its indecisive king—Frederick William III—but his wife, Queen Louise, realized the threat that Napoleon's ambitions

posed to Prussia. She convinced her husband to declare war in 1806, and the Prussian Army paraded through Berlin to cheering crowds as they marched to battle. Later (romanticized) accounts claimed that Louise, who urged men and women in Prussia to resist the French, led the Queen's Dragoons in the procession wearing a crimson and blue colonel's uniform. Louise accompanied Prussian forces to meet Napoleon at the Battle of Jena-Auerstedt, and, despite the bloody defeat, stayed on the battlefield until the bitter end.

After numerous defeats, Prussia was forced to sue for peace in 1807 and Louise, pregnant at the time, personally appealed to Napoleon for clemency at the negotiations. Her pleas were ignored, but Louise nonetheless became

► Held as a heroine

Belgian soldier Marie Schellinck fought for France, disguised as a man. Paintings glorified her as the first woman to be awarded the Legion of Honor by Napoleon, but there are no records of her having received it.

